To: Tech Nation UK

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EXCEPTIONAL TALENT RECOMMENDATION FOR RAPHEAL OBODUGO

I am Adewale Yusuf, Founder of AltSchool Africa. AltSchool's mission is to train engineers on the continent to compete at the highest global standard, which means I spend considerable professional energy thinking about what genuine technical excellence looks like, how it develops, and how rarely it is actually present in someone who also claims it. I write this letter in that spirit of careful assessment, and I write it in support of Raphael Prince Obodugo.

I have known Raphael through the West African technology community since approximately 2022, through shared industry events, public work, and the kind of reputation that travels through a small ecosystem before it reaches the press. That is roughly three years of direct and indirect observation.

There are two dimensions on which I consider him to stand clearly apart from the field.

The first is public recognition as an authority in artificial intelligence and the future of work. In early 2025, Raphael was selected by CNBC Africa as a panelist for their Power Lunch West Africa programme, a live, in-studio broadcast on how AI is reshaping employment and skills development across the continent. His co-panelists were Professor Olayinka David-West, Dean of Lagos Business School, and Emmanuel Okeleji, CEO of SeamlessHR. I mention those names not incidentally but because they indicate the threshold at which CNBC Africa's editorial team placed Raphael. Broadcasters assembling a panel on a topic of continental significance do not seat unknown quantities next to institutional

figureheads. They select for credibility. That selection is itself an act of recognition. The Nation newspaper independently profiled him in October 2025, documenting a career that spans engineering leadership across Nigeria, Saudi Arabia, Singapore, and Europe. These are not manufactured credentials. They are the result of independent editorial decisions by separate organisations.

The second dimension is his contribution to shared software infrastructure. Raphael has made merged contributions to open source Node.js packages that underpin significant portions of production web infrastructure globally, including libraries with monthly download figures in the hundreds of millions. For someone whose primary vocation is commercial product development, the decision to invest time in improving shared infrastructure is a meaningful signal. It is the behaviour of an engineer who thinks at the level of the field, not only at the level of their current employer.

At AltSchool, we have a considered view of what the pipeline of world-class African engineers looks like. Raphael represents the output of that pipeline at its most developed: internationally tested, technically rigorous, and still oriented toward the problems of his home context. His plan to build AVAE from the United Kingdom reflects a logical next step in that trajectory. The UK's concentration of AI research, capital, and talent infrastructure is the appropriate environment for the stage of company he is building.

On the basis of his technical contributions, his public recognition as an AI authority, and his demonstrated ability to build and scale products of genuine social and commercial consequence, I offer my full support for Raphael Obodugo's application for the UK Global Talent Visa. He meets the bar this designation is intended to identify.

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